TACKLING OBESITY IN INDIA

THE ROLE OF BARIATRIC AND METABOLIC SURGERY

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Metabolic and Bariatric Surgery in Current Era in India

Obesity is a global pandemic, and India is not spared from the disease burden as revealed by the National family Health Survey (NFHS-5) which showed a prevalence of overweight/ obesity in 24% of women and 22.9% of men, with a sharp jump from 2015 figures. While mild to moderate obesity can be treated by diet, lifestyle changes, and drugs, severe obesity (BMI > 40) is best treated by metabolic and bariatric surgery, with data showing weight loss of 30-40% at 1 year and 25% at 10 years. Newer drugs (GLP -1 analogues such as semaglutide and tirzepatide) are reasonable alternatives producing 10-20% weight loss at 1 year. The downside of medicines is that once stopped, patients regain weight, and therefore, it needs to be continued lifelong. Considering the cost of medications is Rs 14000 to 20000 per month, this translates into a costly treatment for many middle-income group patients. In contrast, surgery is a single-shot treatment that gives durable and significant weight loss in the majority. Despite this data, the utilization of surgery is paradoxically poor in our resource-stricken country. This needs to be addressed by spreading awareness, insurance ease, and government policy.



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RISING TREND OF OBESITY IN BIHAR & JHARKHAND: BARIATRIC SURGERY; A RAY OF HOPE.....

Hathras, like many parts of Uttar Pradesh, has been facing a severe water crisis. Groundwater levels have been steadily declining and with erratic rainfall patterns. Obesity is emerging as a major health concern in Bihar and Jharkhand, driven by rapid urbanization, sedentary lifestyles, and unhealthy dietary habits, stressful work culture. Increasing numbers of people, including younger adults, are experiencing obesity-related conditions such as type 2 diabetes, hypertension, sleep apnea, joint disorders, PCOD due to obesity, Depression. Bariatric surgery offers a highly effective solution for individuals with severe obesity who have not achieved results through diet and exercise alone. Procedures like gastric bypass, sleeve gastrectomy, Mini gastric bypass, Sleeve plus procedures, Intra-gastric balloons not only support long-term weight loss but also improve or resolve comorbid conditions. In Bihar and Jharkhand, the scope for bariatric surgery is expanding, particularly in urban centers like Patna, Ranchi, and Jamshedpur, where advanced medical facilities and trained surgeons are becoming available. Earlier patients used to travel to the metropolitan cities for the same but nowadays, Advanced surgical procedures are being performed in tier 2 cities as well. However, barriers such as lack of awareness, limited insurance coverage, and cultural misconceptions still hinder growth. With the right initiatives, bariatric surgery can play a vital role in combating obesity and improving overall public health in the region.

India's Obesity Alarming Rise

- 1 in 4 women & 1 in 5 men are overweight or obese (NFHS-5)
- Huge jump from 2015 figures
- Linked to poor diet, inactivity, stress & urban lifestyle

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